

Comedy Screenwriting Craft System: Tina Fey × Donald Glover

Transferable Technique Patterns for 2D Animated Comedy Shorts with Emotional Depth

This analysis treats Fey and Glover as a complementary pair — a machine-gun satirist and a surrealist poet — whose techniques, mapped structurally, can be combined into a unified craft system for short-form animated comedy. Every technique below is reverse-engineered from specific work, not summarized from biography.

1. Dialogue Mechanics

Fey: Machine-Gun Construction

Fey's dialogue operates on a principle of **joke layering** — multiple comedic payloads compressed into single lines. The most cited example is the 30 Rock moment where Jenna responds to Liz's Sling Blade impression with "No, you don't, Oprah." Dan Harmon has called this the best joke in 30 Rock, and analysis reveals at least five simultaneous layers: (1) Jenna misidentifies the impression, (2) her "impression" is just her normal voice, (3) she violates the cardinal improv rule of "Yes, And" by saying "no," (4) the casting inversion is absurd, and (5) it deepens Jenna's character as confidently incompetent. This density isn't accidental — it's engineered through collaborative ping-ponging. Robert Carlock describes their writing process at 30 Rock as "pitching that joke was a real back-and-forth with Tina, like every other word," where they dare each other to push a joke further with each pass.[1][2][3]

The measurable result: 30 Rock achieved **7.44 jokes per minute**, the highest rate among measured sitcoms — more than one joke every eight seconds, surpassing New Girl (7.11), Parks and Recreation (6.97), and The Office (6.65). This density is structurally supported by character-voice distinction. Each character occupies a different **reference pool**:^[4]^[5]

Character	Verbal Domain	Sample Register	Comic Function
Liz Lemon	Food, pop culture, self-deprecation	"I pretty much just do whatever Oprah tells me to"	Everywoman deflation
Jack Donaghy	Corporate strategy, Republican ideology, luxury	"It's after six. What am I, a farmer?"	Grandiose inflation
Tracy Jordan	Non-sequiturs, conspiracy, self-mythology	"That's not me. That's a Tracy Jordan Japanese Sex Doll"	Surreal escalation
Kenneth Parcell	Rural piety, naive optimism, accidental wisdom	"I don't vote Republican or Democrat. Choosing is a sin"	Innocent subversion
Jenna Maroney	Vanity, celebrity gossip, sexual misadventure	Mickey Rourke's sex grill references	Narcissistic oblivion

6

When these characters collide in a scene, comedy emerges from **register collision** — the structural intersection of incompatible vocabularies occupying the same conversational space. Jack delivers a corporate strategy monologue while Liz fixates on food; the comedy isn't in either register alone but in their rhythmic interplay.

The throwaway technique: 30 Rock scripts background gags, visual jokes, and one-off lines that don't get narrative emphasis. Frank Rossitano's trucker hats bear a different cryptic slogan every episode ("Shark Cop," "Half Centaur," "Space Gravy"). These aren't improvised — they're written into wardrobe notes, designed to reward rewatching. Similarly, fake movie titles (Tracy's filmography: *A Blaffair to Rememblack*, *Who Dat Ninja?*, *Honky Grandma Be Trippin'*) appear in backgrounds and throwaway dialogue, each functioning as a compressed satire of Hollywood racial politics.[7]

Callback architecture: 30 Rock plants joke seeds that pay off across episodes and seasons. Jack mentions that Kenneth and Clay Aiken are cousins — a detail never revisited by Kenneth, creating humor from the asymmetry of information. Kenneth's implied immortality begins as background oddities and escalates across seven seasons into a full mythology. The technique: introduce a detail casually (low emphasis), let it recur at irregular intervals (building recognition), then escalate it to absurdity (payoff through accumulation).[8][7]

Glover: Naturalistic Layering

Glover's dialogue operates on a fundamentally different principle: **conversations that sound unscripted but carry structural weight through subtext and tonal shifts**. Atlanta's dialogue is written, not improvised — the show is shot on film, meticulously scripted. But it's designed to sound meandering, casual, as if overheard rather than performed.[9]

The key technique is **register-shifting within a single conversation**. In a single scene, Glover's characters can move from mundane small talk to philosophy to social commentary to surreal non-sequitur without any signal to the audience that the register has changed. In the "B.A.N." episode (S1E7), Paper Boi appears on a fake talk show where the host and an academic overanalyze his rap lyrics as transphobic. Paper Boi responds to their elaborate academic framing with "Nope" and "Please, please. Tell me about myself" — lines that function simultaneously as comedy (the deflation of pretension), social commentary (who gets to define Black expression), and character work (Paper Boi's authentic frustration with being spoken for).[10][11]

Character voice distinction in Atlanta operates through behavioral speech patterns rather than Fey's reference-pool system:

Character	Speech Pattern	Subtext Strategy
Earn	Educated vocabulary in casual delivery, hedging, indirect requests	Always performing competence he isn't sure he possesses
Paper Boi (Alfred)	Direct, blunt, occasionally profound without intending to be	Says exactly what he means, which is funnier than any constructed joke
Darius	Serene non-sequiturs, philosophical tangents, deadpan delivery	Operates on a different plane of logic entirely
Van	Code-switches between informal and precise, German cultural references	Navigates multiple identities simultaneously

12

Silence as dialogue tool: Where Fey fills every second with a joke, Glover uses silence as a comedic and dramatic instrument. Director Hiro Murai has described their approach as deliberately leaving "empty frames" — a technique their editor initially warned against because it "completely kills the rhythm," which turned out to be exactly the effect they wanted. When characters in Atlanta don't respond, or respond incorrectly, or change the subject, the silence becomes the text. The audience fills the gap with discomfort, recognition, or dread. This is scripted as deliberate beat directions and scene-ending holds rather than dialogue.[14]

Murai has articulated the philosophy behind this restraint: "It's uh, it's like someone who talks way too much. You're going to be more interested in the story of someone who is deliberate with their words and takes their time than someone who's trying to talk you to death". [14]

Where They Overlap

Both Fey and Glover use **incongruity as the engine of dialogue comedy** — they just calibrate it differently. Fey creates incongruity through *simultaneous* register collision (two vocabularies in the same scene, happening at once). Glover creates it through *sequential* register shifting (one conversation drifting through multiple registers over time). Both techniques produce the same audience effect: the gap between what's expected and what's delivered generates the laugh or the emotional resonance.

For a 3-5 minute animated short, the combinable technique is: open with Glover-style naturalistic conversation (grounding), then accelerate into Fey-style density as the scene escalates. The opening establishes character reality; the acceleration rewards attention and creates climactic energy. Silence can function as a punctuation mark between Fey-density bursts — a structural rest that makes the next burst hit harder.

2. Scene Construction

Fey: The Joke-Dense Sitcom Scene

A typical 30 Rock scene follows a **compression architecture**: establish the situation in 2-3 lines, introduce the comic engine (usually a collision between two characters' agendas), escalate through rapid joke exchanges, and button with a punchline that either caps the scene or pivots to the next story thread. The entire sequence typically runs 60-90 seconds in a show that averages 7+ scenes per 21-minute episode.[15][16]

The cold open as craft form: 30 Rock's cold opens are self-contained mini-sketches that typically run 30-90 seconds before the title card. They function as tone-setters and often feature standalone comedic situations that may or may not connect to the episode's A-story. The structure is almost always: normal situation → absurd revelation → button. For example, a cold open might show Liz arriving at work normally, then reveal an escalating absurdity that's been happening off-screen, buttoned by a character's deadpan reaction.[17][18]

A/B/C story weaving: 30 Rock runs three concurrent storylines per episode, each occupying roughly: A-story (45-50% of screen time), B-story (30-35%), C-story (15-20%). The weave pattern is not random — storylines intersect at specific structural beats, usually around the midpoint and the climax. Storylines are thematically linked even when they're narratively separate: if the A-story is about Liz's need for control, the B-story might feature Jack losing control, and the C-story might show Tracy exercising chaotic freedom.[19][20]

Ensemble scene management: When 4+ characters share a scene, Fey keeps everyone active through **distributed joke assignment** — each character gets at least one line that serves their voice. No character is reduced to a reactor. The technique is: assign each character a distinct *want* within the scene (even if minor), then let those wants collide. Tracy wants attention, Jenna wants validation, Jack wants resolution, Liz wants everyone to stop — these competing agendas generate comic friction without any character being passive. [20][6]

Glover: The Drift Mechanic

Atlanta's scene construction operates on what can be called a **drift mechanic** — scenes begin in a grounded, recognizable reality and gradually drift toward the surreal, the horrific, or the philosophically disorienting without any clear transition point.

"Teddy Perkins" (S2E6) is the masterclass. Darius answers a mysterious message board posting about a piano for sale. He arrives at a mansion. The scene begins as a straightforward transaction. Then details accumulate: Teddy Perkins's unsettling appearance (Glover in whiteface prosthetics), the house's oppressive atmosphere, references to abusive father figures. The episode was shot with no commercial breaks, runs 34 minutes (longer than standard), and Glover stayed in character as Teddy for the entire production — crew referred to him as "Teddy" on set, and co-star LaKeith Stanfield didn't know it was Glover. Director Murai and cinematographer Christian Sprenger drew on Kubrick's *The Shining* for the visual language, and Murai described looking at Glover in makeup as "like looking into a doll's face — uncanny and unsettling".[21][22]

The **structural mechanic** of the drift: each scene beat slightly raises the temperature — not through joke escalation (as Fey would) but through **accumulating wrongness**. Normal details become slightly off, then more off, then clearly wrong, then terrifying. The audience can never identify the exact moment the comedy became horror because there was no single pivot — just continuous drift.

Tonal ambiguity is constructed in the screenplay through **dual-register staging**: situations are simultaneously funny and disturbing, and the script never resolves the ambiguity. In "Helen" (S2E4), Van brings Earn to a German Oktoberfest in rural Georgia. The *Get Out* parallels are deliberate — a Black couple driving into White County, nearly hitting a boar on the road. But the episode plays simultaneously as relationship drama (Van and Earn's incompatibility), cultural comedy (Earn bewildered by German festival games), and racial tension (coded hostility from white townspeople). Writer Taofik Kolade, in his TV writing debut, structured this ambiguity by never letting any single register dominate — the audience never settles into "this is a comedy scene" or "this is a horror scene".[23][24][25]

Bottle episode technique: "Helen" also demonstrates Glover's approach to confined settings. By trapping characters in a single location with clear social rules (the festival), the script amplifies tension through claustrophobia. Earn cannot leave, cannot code-switch effectively, cannot find comfortable footing — and the confined setting makes every micro-interaction a potential escalation. The barbershop scene Stephen Glover cited as a favorite operates similarly: Alfred's frustration with barber Bibby's distractions plays out in a single chair, with no escape.[26]

Ensemble Comparison

Both Fey and Glover are ensemble masters, but they manage ensembles for opposite effects:

Dimensi on	Fey's Ensemble Scenes	Glover's Ensemble Scenes
Primary goal	Maximum comedy output	Maximum tension or tonal complexity
Characte r activity	Everyone gets jokes; distributed evenly	Power dynamics determine who speaks and who's silent
Scene engine	Competing wants collide for comic friction	Social pressure accumulates through observation
Pacing	Rapid-fire; no dead air	Deliberate; silence carries meaning
Resolutio n	Button/punchline that caps the scene	Ambiguous exit; audience left unsettled

For a 3-5 minute short, the structural choice between these approaches depends on the emotional target. If the short aims for cathartic energy (audience leaves laughing), use Fey's ensemble architecture. If it aims for lingering resonance (audience leaves thinking), use Glover's. The hybrid: open with Fey-style comic friction among an ensemble, then shift one character into Glover-territory discomfort, letting the comedy curdle into something more complex in the final beat.

3. Structural Patterns

Fey: Reliable Architecture

30 Rock's episode structure is a well-oiled machine: cold open → A/B/C story introduction (Act 1) → complication and intersection (Act 2) → resolution and button (Act 3), all within 21 minutes. The audience always knows what kind of show they're watching. This reliability is a feature, not a limitation — it creates a contract with the viewer that allows Fey to pack extreme density and absurdity into every scene because the audience trusts the structural container.[27][15]

Season-level structure: 30 Rock uses a reset model — most episodes return characters to baseline, with slow-burn seasonal arcs (Jack's career trajectory, Liz's romantic life) providing forward momentum. Individual episodes can be watched out of order without confusion, but sequential viewing rewards callback recognition.[27]

Mean Girls feature structure: Fey's film writing adheres closely to classical three-act structure. The first act runs almost exactly 30 minutes, establishing characters and world. The inciting incident (Cady deciding to infiltrate the Plastics) occurs at 29:30. The midpoint (Cady becoming what she set out to destroy) hits at the one-hour mark. The third act resolves through a public reckoning (the assembly scene) that changes not just the protagonist but the entire school ecosystem. Fey's feature technique: side characters are more active than the protagonist — the Plastics and Janis drive the plot while Cady reacts, which is structurally unusual and creates the impression of a world that operates independently of the main character.[28][29][30]

Setup and payoff mastery: Mean Girls is a case study in planting details early that pay off later — Fey's comedy background trained her to think in terms of setups and callbacks, and she applies this at feature length with remarkable discipline, where nearly 85% of dialogue transferred unchanged from screenplay to screen.[31]

Glover: Unpredictable Architecture

Atlanta's structure is deliberately unstable. Each episode can be a different genre — comedy, horror, mockumentary, sketch anthology, social thriller — and the audience has no structural contract. Glover and Murai have described the show's world as "malleable," where "each episode expands the narrative sandbox a little more" and this evolution "wasn't planned from the outset; it just naturally unfolded". [32][33]

Anthology coherence: Seasons 3 and 4 of Atlanta include standalone episodes with entirely new casts and no main characters. These maintain series coherence through **thematic threading** rather than narrative connection. Season 3's anthology episodes all explore variations on a "curse of whiteness" theme — racial reckoning, cultural appropriation, white savior complexes — while the main cast

episodes explore the disorientation of Black Americans in Europe. The standalone episodes function as dream logic: disconnected in plot but connected in subconscious preoccupation.[34][35]

"B.A.N." (S1E7) structural experiment: The entire episode abandons the show's format to present a fake talk show with fake commercials. Paper Boi appears as a frustrated guest; the fake commercials (including an animated cereal commercial where a cop brutalizes a Black version of the Trix rabbit) carry more social commentary than the talk show segments. The structure mirrors actual TV viewing — commercial breaks interrupt narrative flow — and the commentary is embedded in the structure itself, not just the content. Glover doesn't need characters to state a thesis because the form is the argument.[36][10]

Signaling rule changes: Atlanta signals tonal and structural shifts through visual and pacing cues rather than dialogue exposition. Murai's approach begins by identifying the "emotional moves" of a scene rather than plotting shots, building outward from an instinctive "guttural reaction". When an episode opens differently than expected (no opening credits in "Helen," no main characters in "Three Slaps"), the audience registers the structural break as a signal that the rules have changed.[14]

When to Use Each for 3-5 Minute Shorts

Approach	Best For	Risk
Fey's reliable structure	Series of shorts where audience returns weekly; building character equity; maximizing joke density	Can feel formulaic at short length
Glover's unpredictable structure	One-off shorts; festival submissions; prestige animation; emotional resonance	Audience may not "get it" without prior trust
Hybrid	Short series where episodes 1-3 establish Fey-style reliability, then episode 4+ breaks the contract Glover-style	Requires audience investment before the subversion lands

At 3-5 minutes, **A/B story weaving doesn't work** — there isn't enough screen time to establish, develop, and resolve two parallel stories. The compressed structure should be: single story, 3-4 scenes, with the Fey technique of thematic echo replacing literal plot intersection. If your A-scene is about a character failing at cooking, your B-beat (not a full B-story) might be a background gag about something else failing — thematic resonance without structural complexity.

4. Comedy Mechanics (Deep Dive)

Fey's Joke Taxonomy

Type	Construction	Example Mechanic
Layered word play	Multiple meanings compressed into single line	Jack's "Let me be the Michelle Pfeiffer to your angry black kid who learns poetry is just another form of rap" — simultaneously absurd casting, movie critique, race commentary, and character revelation[37]
Callback	Plant casually → recur irregularly → escalate	Kenneth's immortality: background hints in early seasons become full mythology by series end[7]
Character-based	Joke is funny <i>because</i> of who says it	Tracy's lines would be non-sequiturs from anyone else; from Tracy, they're character-consistent surrealism
Absurd escalation	Normal premise pushed past logic into madness	Dr. Spaceman covered in blood: each explanation more disturbing than the last, with Fey and Carlock "daring each other to take it ever further"[2]
Register collision	Two incompatible vocabularies in the same space	Liz's food vocabulary punctuating Jack's corporate strategy speeches
Throwaway/background	Jokes that don't require audience attention	Frank's hat slogans, fake movie titles, background signs[7]

Social commentary through comedy: Fey's technique for keeping commentary funny rather than preachy is **displacement through absurdity**. Mean Girls examines social hierarchies by comparing high school to the African savanna — the metaphor is so absurd it defuses the lecture quality. 30 Rock addresses media capitalism by having Jack embody it so enthusiastically that his sincerity becomes the joke. The commentary is never delivered by the "voice of reason" character (Liz) but by the characters who represent the problem (Jack, Jenna, Tracy), which makes the satire emerge from character behavior rather than authorial commentary.[38][20]

Glover's Comedy Taxonomy

Type	Construction	Example Mechanic
Awkwardness humor	Social discomfort held too long, no release valve	Earn fumbling German festival customs in "Helen" — the laugh comes from sustained incompetence[23]
Surreal humor	Reality bends without announcement	Black Justin Bieber exists in Atlanta's world with no explanation; invisible cars; alligator man
Social observation	Everyday absurdities of being Black in America, stated plainly	Paper Boi on Caitlyn Jenner: "just another rich white man doing what rich white men always do — whatever they want"[10]
Character comedy	Darius's unflappable serenity in insane circumstances	Darius approaches Teddy Perkins's mansion with curiosity rather than fear
Meta-humor	The show comments on its own medium	B.A.N.'s fake commercials satirize the advertising that supports the actual network Atlanta airs on[10][39]

Social commentary through structure: Where Fey displaces commentary into absurd metaphor, Glover **embeds it into the structural choices themselves**. The B.A.N. episode doesn't have a character explain that Black media is commercialized — instead, fake commercials *structurally interrupt* the fake talk show, and the form itself demonstrates the argument. The "Teddy Perkins" episode doesn't lecture about how racism destroys families — it puts the audience in a horror movie where a man's face has literally been bleached into something inhuman. Glover's structural choice that enables going darker: he doesn't resolve the tension. Where Fey's scenes button with a punchline (releasing pressure), Glover's scenes often end with the pressure still building, carried into the next scene or left unresolved entirely.[21][10]

Combinable Techniques for a Single Short

The techniques that coexist most naturally:

- **Fey's character-voice distinction + Glover's register-shifting:** Give each character a clear verbal identity (Fey), then let conversations drift through multiple tonal registers without announcement (Glover). The distinct voices make the shifts legible; the shifts create emotional complexity.
 - **Fey's absurd escalation + Glover's refusal to resolve:** Build a scene using Fey-style escalation (each beat more absurd than the last), but don't button it with a clean punchline. Instead, let the escalation reach a point where it stops being funny and becomes something else — uncomfortable, poignant, strange.
 - **Fey's throwaway jokes + Glover's thematic coherence:** Pack background details with Fey-style visual gags, but ensure each background gag thematically echoes the scene's emotional content (Glover). The audience laughs at the surface joke; rewatching reveals the deeper pattern.
 - **Fey's joke density for the first two-thirds + Glover's silence for the final third:** Use the rapid-fire approach to establish comedic energy and character, then drop into deliberate pacing for the emotional climax. The shift in rhythm signals to the audience that something has changed.
-

5. Transferable Techniques for Short-Form

Sitcom Structure Compressed

A 21-minute sitcom like 30 Rock contains ~7 scenes and runs 3 storylines. A 3-5 minute short contains 3-5 scenes and can sustain **one story with one tonal counterpoint**. The A/B/C weave collapses to an A-story with a thematic B-element (a recurring visual gag, a background subplot expressed in 2-3 quick beats, or a secondary character's parallel reaction).

The compressed scene template:

1. **Scene 1 (0:00-1:00)**: Establish character, world, and comic engine. Fey's technique: the first scene should contain a joke that reveals character. Glover's technique: the first scene should feel like you're walking into a conversation already in progress.
2. **Scene 2 (1:00-2:30)**: Escalate. This is where Fey's density mechanics earn their keep — pack this scene with the highest joke-per-minute rate. Alternatively, use Glover's drift mechanic to let the situation grow stranger.
3. **Scene 3 (2:30-4:00)**: Resolve or refuse to resolve. Fey buttons with a punchline; Glover exits with ambiguity. For emotional depth, the hybrid: resolve the comedic premise but leave the emotional question open.
4. **Optional Scene 4 (4:00-5:00)**: Tag/coda. Both Fey and Glover use end-tags effectively (30 Rock's end-of-episode tags, Community's iconic "Troy and Abed" tags that Glover performed). A 5-second to 30-second coda after the emotional climax can reframe the entire short.[40]

Joke Density Calibration

Format	Target Jokes/Minute	Reasoning
30 Rock-style sitcom	7+	Established audience, trust, character equity allows pure density[4]
Comedy short (3-5 min)	4-6	Less character equity; audience needs orientation beats
Glover-style tonal short	2-3 (with weight)	Each joke carries more narrative load; silence does work
Hybrid animated short	5 in first half, 2-3 in second half	Density establishes comedy contract; slowdown creates emotional shift

The rhythm change: in a sitcom, the joke rhythm is relatively constant. In a short, the rhythm should **decelerate** — starting faster and ending slower. This mirrors music structure (verse energy → bridge slowdown → final chorus resolution) and creates the feeling of emotional deepening.

Sketch Techniques That Transfer

Both Fey and Glover have sketch comedy DNA. Fey's SNL training established the fundamental sketch structure: premise → game → escalation → blackout/button. Glover's Derrick Comedy work at NYU built on commitment to absurd premises played straight — his "Mad Hatter" sketch shows gradual descent into madness delivered with complete sincerity.[41][42][43]

Transferable sketch mechanics for animated narrative shorts:

- **The Game:** Every sketch has a "game" — the single funny thing the sketch explores. In a narrative short, identify the game (the core comic mechanism) and make sure every scene plays it. "Character tries to be cool but keeps revealing they're not" is a game. "Two people having the same conversation but about completely different things" is a game.

- **Heightening:** Sketch comedy escalates the game in each beat. Transfer this to animated shorts by making each scene a more extreme version of the previous one.
- **The Straight Man:** Sketch requires at least one character who recognizes the absurdity. In animated shorts, this character is the audience's proxy and is essential for emotional grounding.
- **The Blackout:** Sketch ends on the biggest version of the game or an inversion. Animated shorts can use this as the climax, then add a brief emotional coda afterward (something sketch doesn't do, but narrative requires).

Dan Harmon's *Community* scripts would literally include the stage direction "And then Donald says something funny" — a placeholder for Glover to riff — and Glover would consistently deliver lines funnier than the writers' room could produce. This isn't useful for a solo creator, but the principle is: leave room in your script for the *performance* to elevate the writing, especially in animation where vocal delivery is everything.[44]

Minimum Viable Ensemble

A 3-minute animated short can support **2-3 distinct characters** at most. The minimum viable ensemble for comedy requires:

- **The Driver:** The character with the want (Fey's Liz, Glover's Earn)
- **The Disruptor:** The character who prevents the Driver from getting what they want (Fey's Jack/Tracy, Glover's Darius/Paper Boi)
- **Optional: The Observer:** A character who comments on or reacts to the collision (Fey's Kenneth, Glover-style silent witness)

At 3 minutes, give each character a maximum of one defining trait expressed through their voice. Fey's character-distinction technique scales down well: assign each character a single reference pool (one talks in food metaphors, one talks in gaming metaphors, one talks in weather metaphors) and let the reference pools collide.

Writing Room Techniques for Solo Creators

Fey's room runs on **collaborative punch-up** — scripts go through multiple passes where every line is examined for whether it can be funnier, sharper, or more character-specific. Carlock describes the core discipline as "trying not only to amuse each other, but to ask the most annoying questions — does that track, could this be better?".[45]
[2][3]

For a solo creator, simulate this with:

1. **First pass:** Write the story. Don't worry about jokes.
2. **Second pass (Fey pass):** Go line by line and ask: can this line contain a joke? Can this joke contain a second joke? Can this second joke also reveal character? Apply the layered-joke principle — look for places where a single line can do multiple jobs.
3. **Third pass (Glover pass):** Go scene by scene and ask: is there a moment where silence would be funnier or more powerful than a joke? Is there a place where the tone could productively shift? Where does the audience expect a punchline that you could withhold?
4. **Fourth pass (table read):** Read the script aloud, timing it. 30 Rock conducted table reads approximately one week before shooting, then rewrote based on the room's reactions — laughs, silences, and confused looks all provided data. As a solo creator, record yourself reading it and play it back. The places where your energy drops are the places the audience will tune out.[45]

6. Process

Fey's Writing Room Methodology

The 30 Rock writers' room operated on a high-volume, high-iteration model inherited from Fey's SNL experience. At SNL, writers submit dozens of sketches weekly, and only a handful make it to air — a process Fey has described as both brutal and liberating because "the biggest gift they give you is the constant failure and the feeling of like, okay, I failed so deeply and I survived".[2]

At 30 Rock, the process ran: writers pitch story ideas → stories are selected and broken in the room → individual writers (or pairs) draft scripts → table read with cast and ~25 people → rewrite based on table read feedback → rehearsal and shooting on a 12-14 hour day schedule. Fey and Carlock functioned as the final filter, with Carlock bringing "erudite references and absurd joke constructions" and Fey bringing structural sharpness and character instinct.[3][45]

The collaboration model was built on creative daring. Fey and Carlock's most celebrated jokes emerged from one pushing the other further: "So much of collaboration is trying not only to amuse each other, but to ask the most annoying questions — does that track, could this be better? It's torture in the process, but it does ultimately lead to a better product".[2]

Glover's Creative Process

Atlanta's writers' room was deliberately small and unconventional. Donald Glover hired an all-Black writing staff, most of whom had never written for television before — a choice driven by authenticity rather than credentials. As Stephen Glover explained: "We used to talk about how this show shouldn't be a show about rappers; it should be a show for rappers". Donald Glover stated the intent clearly: "I wanted to show white people, you don't know everything about Black culture".[46][12]

The room grew across seasons but remained intimate. The creative process centered on emotional truth over structural convention. Murai has described their approach: "whenever we break down a script, we usually schedule the shot list thing but what we actually do really is just kind of break down the kind of emotional sort of moves of a scene... so we talk about what's interesting to us personally about each scene".[14]

The guiding creative principle evolved with the show. By season 4, Glover's directive was simply "Have more fun. Act like you're going to get canceled" — a return to the risk-taking mentality of season 1, where the attitude was essentially that the show wasn't "supposed to be on TV" so they might as well take every creative risk available. Murai confirmed that Glover gave the team "free reign" with the instruction: "I want this show to get canceled — I don't think this

show is supposed to be on TV but they let us have it so we should" make the most extreme version possible.[47][14]

The Fey-Glover Connection

These processes aren't as distant as they appear. **Glover was trained in Fey's room.** He was hired at 23 to write for 30 Rock after Fey spotted his Derrick Comedy work on YouTube, and he stayed for three seasons. Fey writes in *Bossypants* that "because he came from a large family in Georgia, he was very helpful in writing for the character Kenneth the Page". Glover has described the experience as formative: "I decided I wanted to write for television because of Tina. She was always so happy, and I was like, I want to be happy like that too".[48][49][50]

Glover absorbed Fey's structural discipline — how to construct a joke, how to run a room, how to manage ensemble voices — and then deliberately inverted many of those principles in Atlanta. Where 30 Rock filled every second, Atlanta left space. Where 30 Rock's structure was reliable, Atlanta's was volatile. Where 30 Rock's comedy was dense and verbal, Atlanta's was sparse and behavioral. This isn't rebellion — it's mastery of the rules followed by intentional subversion. Understanding both systems gives a writer the full spectrum of comedy craft.

Rewriting and Punch-Up

Both Fey and Glover treat rewriting as essential rather than optional, but their approaches differ:

Fey's punch-up: Line-by-line examination. Can this joke be funnier? Can it do double duty (funny AND character-revealing)? The 30 Rock room would identify "joke deserts" — stretches of more than 8-10 seconds without a laugh — and target them for additional comedy. Carlock's rule: "Jokes are just surprises" — if a line is predictable, it needs work.[2]

Glover's refinement: Scene-level examination. Does this scene feel true? Does the tone do what we intended? Is there a place where we're over-explaining? The Atlanta room's instinct was toward reduction rather than addition — cutting dialogue, extending silences,

trusting the audience to fill gaps. Stephen Glover's favorite dialogue came from the barbershop's opening scene because it captured authentic voice without any joke construction.[26]

For solo animated short creators: Run both passes. The Fey pass adds jokes and density. The Glover pass strips away anything that feels explained rather than experienced. The final product should feel dense but effortless — every joke earned, every silence intentional.

References

1. [When you're so good at writing that you put three jokes in ... - YouTube](#) - " is the best joke from '30 Rock.' And for good reason — there's something that makes this joke spec...
2. [Tina Fey and Robert Carlock Talk Collaboration, Joke-Building at ...](#) - The duo behind 30 Rock and Unbreakable Kimmy Schmidt shared insights as part of the Learning from Pe...
3. [Easy as 1, 2, 3 | Television Academy](#) - By the end of 30 Rock, Carlock says he and Fey were better friends. They had had more kids with thei...
4. [The One Where I Counted the Jokes in Popular Sitcoms - The Atlantic](#) - An unscientific survey shows the most-viewed TV comedy shows tend keep the humor to a measured pace.
5. [Tina Fey's Massive Comedic Influence, from 'Mean Girls' to '30 Rock ...](#) - In 2014, a writer for The Atlantic actually calculated the rate of jokes per minute of TV's most pop...
6. [Individualised dialogue – an example from 30 Rock - Tom Salinsky](#) - A well-known test of dialogue is to cover up the character names in your script and see if you can s...
7. [30 Rock's Best Running Jokes | Den of Geek](#) - Join us in celebrating the many, many running gags of its seven-season history, from the fake movies...
8. [Binge It! 30 Rock Is a Classic at 7.44 Jokes Per Minute - IGN](#) - A writer for The Atlantic once did the math and averaged that the show includes about 7.44 jokes per...
9. [Inside the 'absurdist' 'concept album' that is 'Atlanta' Season 3](#) - I think our approach has always been: We write it like a comedy, and we shoot it like a drama. You'r...

10. ['Atlanta' Recap and Reaction: "B.A.N." | Fandom](#) - The episode is a fake half-hour talk show on the BAN network (likely modeled after BET) called "Mont...
11. [Repost: Deadline, '{Atlanta writers}' Address Criticism That FX Series ...](#) - It showcases a fake TV network airing a fake—but all too familiar—talk show, Montague, and the comme...
12. [Atlanta: Why FX comedy ditches 'the PC world' - Entertainment Weekly](#) - Writer Stephen Glover talks the Emmy-nominated FX comedy's success — and why it surprises him.
13. [The Honesty of "Atlanta"](#) - Glover used the broad outlines of a rags-to-riches narrative and the Atlanta rap milieu to examine t...
14. [Director Hiro Murai and Cinematographer Christian Sprenger - Smith'](#) director) on following Donald Glover from videos to comedy to drama ... Hiro Murai ('Atlanta'...
15. [Structural elements and comedic techniques | TV Genres... - Fiveable](#) - The cold open, or teaser, is a short, often humorous scene that precedes the opening credits. Sets t...
16. [30 min TV comedy show act structure question: : r/Screenwriting](#) - A couple of things: Is it a show with a cold open? Because those usually have a Teaser section which...
17. [30 Rock: The Funniest Cold Opens of All Time - YouTube](#) - Most hilarious cold opens from 30 rock season 4. 30 Rock is streaming now on Peacock: <https://pck.tv...>
18. [Favorite Cold Open : r/30ROCK - Reddit](#) - After Liz gets catcalled by what later TWIST turns out to be a closeted construction worker, when Mo...
19. [30 ROCK Pilot Episode Breakdown: Characters & Themes Analysis](#) - A Story: (The A Story is the storyline with the most screen time and scenes. It usually involves the...
20. [Pushing the Boundaries of Comedy: A Review of '30 Rock'](#) - However, "30 Rock" weaves multiple storylines—often more than just A and B—into each episode. This i...
21. [Teddy Perkins - Wikipedia](#) - In a deviation from the typical comedic structure of Atlanta, series creator Donald Glover wrote the...
22. [7 Years After Atlanta's Best Episode, I'm Still Not Sure What The Hell ...](#) - LaKeith Stanfield Did Not Know Donald Glover Was Playing Teddy Perkins. Teddy Perkins (Donald Glover...

23. ['Atlanta' Season 2, Episode 4: Game Over? - The New York Times](#) - Ping-Pong and a German festival helped Van finally confront the reality that's been staring her in t...
24. ['Atlanta' Recap: Season 2, Episode 4, 'Helen' - TheGrio](#) - We learn more about Van and Earn's situationship. "Helen" is this writer's least favorite episode so...
25. [Atlanta Recap Season 2 Episode 4: 'Helen' - Vulture](#) - We really know it's over when Van encounters the monster in the alley, finding her phone, and, maybe...
26. [Atlanta's Stephen Glover on Bringing 'Black Experience' to Season 2](#) - After earning 13 Emmy nominations, writer and director Stephen Glover talks candidly about writers r...
27. [The Ten Best 30 ROCK Episodes of Season One](#) - That is, Fey's 30 Rock is textbook: an ensemble workplace comedy set behind the scenes of a TV show ...
28. [Mean Girls' 3-Act Structure - Cassie's RTF Blog](#) - In the context of Mean Girls, the occurs at 29:30, when Cady and her outcast friends decided to take...
29. [Mean Girls by Tina Fey - Outline - screenplayoutlines.com](#) - Mean Girls by Tina Fey - Outline · 1) Third act is about righting wrongs and making amends. · 2) Thi...
30. [Symposium of Student Scholars: Screenplay Analysis Mean Girls](#) - Screenplay Analysis: An Evaluation of Strategy of Mean Girls Author: Zora Evans This presentation ex...
31. [Setups & Payoffs in Mean Girls | Screenwriting Tips | Scribe Meets World](#) - Setups and payoffs make for an entertaining screenplay. Develop this screenwriting skill by studying...
32. [Screenwriting and Directing Lessons From Donald Glover](#) - For example, in Atlanta, he combines elements of comedy, drama, and surrealism to create a show that...
33. ['Atlanta' Exit Interview: Hiro Murai Breaks Down Seasons 1-4, Finale](#) - In a long exit interview, the producer-director opens up about the series' classic episodes, its evo...
34. [The Latest 'Atlanta' Anthology Episode Was the Most Experimental ...](#) - With just one episode left of the third season, Atlanta veers from the main plotline into an offbeat...
35. [Atlanta Season 3: a complex exploration of blackness and whiteness](#) - Atlanta Season 3: a complex exploration of blackness ... By teasing out underlying themes, they give...

36. [Review: Atlanta Episode Seven, "B.A.N." - The Eagle](#) - A fake commercial about an upscale malt liquor is really funny, but it's simply not the reason I tun...
37. [Remarkable: A 30 Rock Joke - Geoff Klock](#) - In an episode of 30 Rock uber-corporate guy Alec Baldwin wants to teach comedy writer Tina Fey about...
38. [Feminism, Postfeminism, Liz Lemonism: Comedy and Gender ...](#) - 30 Rock is significant precisely for the centrality of feminism and gender politics in Liz Lemon's c...
39. ['Atlanta' Recap: A Good Time to Get Extremely Goofy - Rolling Stone](#) - Late in the first season of Atlanta, we got "B.A.N.," an episode that presented itself as an install...
40. [The First Troy And Abed In The Morning - Community - YouTube](#) - first ever "Troy And Abed In the Morning". This time Troy (Donald Glover) and Abed (Danny Pudi) inte...
41. [Tina Fey On Life, Motherhood, Writing And Comedy - MYNSPR.org](#) - Fey's memoir Bossypants contains her thoughts on juggling motherhood, acting, writing and executive ...
42. [Great Sketches #1: "Progression of a Mad Hatter" by Derrick ...](#) - Donald Glover plays a modern day hatmaker who decides to practice his craft "the old fashioned way",...
43. [Top 10 SNL Sketches You Didn't Know Were Written by Tina Fey](#) - We're pulling back the curtain on some comedic genius! Join us as we explore the brilliant, often au...
44. ['And then Donald says something funny' : r/community - Reddit](#) - It was essentially a work place prank and Donald Glover took it seriously and crushed it. Hilarious.
45. [Bossypants | Tina Fey | Talks at Google - YouTube](#) - Tina Fey joins Google's Executive Chairman Eric Schmidt for a fireside chat about her new book, Boss...
46. [Donald Glover on Why "Atlanta" has an all-black writing staff - Reddit](#) - Donald Glover on Why "Atlanta" has an all-black writing staff: "I wanted to show White people, you d...
47. [Donald Glover's Writing Tip of the Day: "Have more fun... Act like you ...](#) - "As for Season 4 [of Atlanta], Donald Glover says the idea was 'Have more fun. Once you go through t...
48. [How Donald Glover Got His Job at '30 Rock' - Femestella](#) - He had made some short videos for a student improv comedy group and she was hooked. That's all at it...

49. [Donald Glover | Biography, Childish Gambino, TV Shows, Movies](#)
... - In 2006 he was hired as a writer for Tina Fey's new sitcom 30 Rock, and he stayed with the show for ...
50. [TIL that during the early years of 30 Rock, Donald Glover was so](#)
... - Donald Glover was so young when he started on their writing staff that he was still living in a New ...